

Supporting Survivors as Service Providers

“A few things I want to make sure everyone leaves here knowing...”

First and most importantly:

→ It is never the survivor’s fault.

It’s not our job to force someone to leave toxic people or situations. It’s not our job to judge them if they return to those situations. It is our job to come with compassion, understanding, and patience. It’s our responsibility to meet survivors exactly where they are in their life.

Survivors of trafficking might not always make sense from the outside looking in.

You might wonder, “Why do they stay? Why do they go back? Why are they still connected to this person?”

It’s okay if it doesn’t make sense to you.

What matters is understanding the deep impact trafficking has on someone’s body, mind, and spirit.

→ Understand their trauma responses: fight, flight, freeze, or fawn.

→ Understand the “window of tolerance” — if they’re outside of it, they literally can’t engage the way you might expect.

→ Speak without bias or judgment.

→ Remember: anyone, anywhere, from any background can be a victim of trafficking.

Sometimes, the signs will be clear. Survivors might tell you openly what they’ve been through.

Other times, they might not even have the words themselves.

They might only have fear, confusion, or silence — and that’s okay.

Your role is to create safety, not force disclosure.

Practical Ways to Support Survivors of Trafficking:

1. Be consistent and reliable.

Survivors have been let down repeatedly. Showing up builds trust.

2. Avoid ultimatums.

Statements like “You have to cut them off or we can’t help you” push survivors away.

3. Normalize small steps.

Celebrate progress, no matter how small.

4. Validate their feelings.

Hold space for their feelings without rushing to solutions.

5. Practice active listening.

Use open-ended questions, reflect, and avoid interrupting.

6. Understand trauma bonding.

Survivors may still feel connected to their trafficker. Don’t shame this.

7. Keep your biases in check.

Be mindful of judgments — they show, even if unspoken.

8. Use empowering language.

Say “person being exploited” or “survivor,” not harmful labels.

9. Offer choices whenever possible.

Even small choices rebuild autonomy.

10. Collaborate on their goals.

Ask what they want to work toward and co-create plans.

11. Be patient. Healing takes time.

Relapse or disconnection is part of the process. Stay present.

12. Ensure privacy and safety.

Communal spaces can retraumatize — protect confidentiality.

13. Support self-regulation.

Offer grounding techniques or coping tools during distress.

14. Respect fragmented disclosure.

Survivors disclose in pieces. Respond to every part with care.

15. Acknowledge intersectionality.

Race, disability, immigration, LGBTQ2S+ status — all matter.

16. Care for yourself.

Decompress, seek peer support, and recognize compassion fatigue.

17. See the whole person.

Celebrate their strengths and resilience, not just their trauma.

Do's & Don'ts for Service Providers



Do:

- Validate survivor experiences, even if they seem contradictory.
- Respect their pace for disclosure and recovery.
- Recognize survival behaviors (fight, flight, freeze, fawn).
- Use non-judgmental, compassionate language.
- Recognize the complexity of trauma bonds.
- Offer choices, big and small.
- Support ongoing recovery — not just crisis response.

- Collaborate instead of prescribing.
- Protect survivor privacy at all times.
- Care for yourself to continue caring for others.



Don't:

- Don't pressure survivors to leave before they feel ready.
- Don't expect gratitude.
- Don't shame coping mechanisms like substance use.
- Don't take withdrawal or testing of trust personally.
- Don't assume full disclosure will happen at once.
- Don't label survivors as manipulative.
- Don't create rigid or punitive rules.
- Don't underestimate how identity factors shape risk.
- Don't ask "Why didn't you just leave?"
- Don't forget: Healing is a long-term journey.

If I can leave you with one final reminder, it's this:

Survivors don't need perfection from you.

They need your presence, your compassion, and your willingness to walk alongside them, no matter where they're at in their journey.

Even when they push you away, even when they seem "resistant" — your consistency is the lifeline they will remember when they're ready to reach back.

Thank you for the work you already do every single day.

You are making more of a difference than you even realize.